

In the Name of God, the Most Benevolent, the Most Compassionate

Rev. Prof. Dr. Ioan Sauca, the Hon. Interim General Secretary of the World Council of Churches

Rev. Dr. David Marshall, The Hon. Program Executive for Muslim-Christian Dialogue at the World Council of Churches

My sincere greetings to you. I am very proud to attend this blessed meeting on the occasion of the Silver Jubilee (twenty-fifth anniversary) of the beginning of dialogue and cooperation with our brothers and sisters in the World Council of Churches.

At the outset of this webinar, I would like to recall the late Ayatollah Taskhiri, who was one of the founders of these dialogues; the impact and development of which we are witnessing today; especially in the field of cooperation and empathy among the followers of different religions. A clear example of this empathy can be seen in the positive response of the world's religious leaders to my letter. Your letter, as the Interim Secretary of the World Council of Churches and other Christian Institutions, to the President of the United States, in defense of the Iranian people and opposing the illegitimate and oppressive sanctions, is one of the fruits of the existing empathy, and I once again express my appreciations and gratitude.

I was also very pleased to read the joint document of the World Council of Churches and the Pontifical Council for Interreligious Dialogue entitled "Serving a Wounded World in Interreligious Solidarity: A Christian Call to Reflection and Action During COVID-19 and Beyond" and I found many similarities in it with Islamic teachings.

In these twenty-five years and during the 9 rounds of dialogue we have had, many achievements have been made. During this relatively long period of time, a magnificent and strong structure has been erected, the foundations of which are based on mutual trust, broad commonalities, the will of the two sides to develop mutual understanding, as well as cooperation in different fields. We, too believe that traversing this path is not an easy task and that dialogue is essentially based on the manners and ethics that you mentioned in your speech. As per our religious beliefs, proper listening is the cause of glad tidings by God Almighty and a good question asked is equal to half of knowledge.

Your Reverend,

The main essence of the divine religions is the call to be a worshipper of God Almighty; an invitation that is based on two fundamental conditions. First, heartfelt belief, and secondly, the manifestation of worshipping God Almighty in the believer's actions. The main and fundamental problem of today's religious believers today is converting beliefs into action. Bad deeds or inaction can both degrade religion to a point that the believer would only be a man of religion in name. The spiritual and moral advice of religions is that believing people traverse the path towards perfection. In this essence, there is no difference between Islam and Christianity. This is the very foundation of commonalities between the two and it is so strong that it can overcome all the small existing differences.

Extremism and the tendency towards violence in the sense of excluding others and excommunicating them have never been accepted in Islam and Christianity. Religion calls for rationality and closes the way to violence, but violence arises in the absence of rationality. Religious extremism, on the one hand, and demeaning religions and attacking religious sanctities and places and spreading hatred, on the other hand, some instance of which we are, unfortunately, witnessing in some countries, especially France, are the two blades of the same pair of scissors aimed at completely eradicating the divine gift of religion and misleading humanity. Unfortunately, all such improper actions have been justified by the French President in the name of freedom of expression, whereas, in all religions, freedom of expression is confined to respecting the rights of others. Fortunately, the two elements of rationality and moderation, have protected the true followers of religions from falling into the abyss of extremism.

Dialogue is also an important element in exercising rationality and avoiding violence. We have always welcomed dialogue with you in the past years and we believe that it has proved to be useful for both of us, and now that we have put behind the past, I hope that we will go on with these dialogues more purposefully than in the past. Dialogues for finding solutions to the crises and problems facing humanity can provide an effective vision, a vision that would bring humanity closer to peace and would isolate enmity and animosity in the human world. I can visualize that day and I have hope in God's blessings in this regard. We sincerely and always extend our hand in friendship and for cooperation to our friends.

Once again my thanks to you and my friends at the World Council of Churches.

Abouzar Ebrahimi

President,

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